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AI Vocabulary for Teachers

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AI vocabulary for teachers

Every AI term you'll actually hear this year — in staff meetings, headlines, and from your students — explained the way you'd explain it to a colleague in the hallway.

The basics

AI (artificial intelligence)	Software that does tasks we used to think required human thinking: writing, summarizing, answering questions. Umbrella term; most of what people mean right now is the next entry.
Generative AI	AI that creates new content — text, images, audio — instead of just sorting or finding things. ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, and Copilot are all generative AI.
Chatbot	The chat-window way of talking to an AI. You type, it replies, the conversation continues with memory of what was said earlier in that chat.
LLM (large language model)	The engine under the chatbot: a model trained on enormous amounts of text to predict what words come next. "Model" and "LLM" get used interchangeably.
Prompt	Whatever you type into the AI. The single biggest factor in whether you get something useful. Better prompt, better draft — every time.
Output / response	What the AI gives back. Treat every output as a first draft from an eager intern: often good, never final, always yours to review.
Iterating	Replying to the AI to improve its draft — "shorter," "warmer," "make it a table" — instead of starting over. Where most of the real value is.

How it works (the honest version)

Training data	The text the model learned from — much of the public internet, books, and licensed sources. Why it knows so much, and why it inherits the internet's mistakes.
Hallucination	When AI states something false with total confidence: invented citations, wrong dates, fake quotes. Not a rare glitch — a built-in behavior. Verify anything factual before it reaches students.
Bias	Patterns from the training data showing up in outputs — assumptions about names, cultures, genders, abilities. Another reason your professional read-through is non-negotiable.
Context window	How much the AI can "hold in mind" in one conversation. Long chats eventually push early details out; if it gets forgetful, start fresh.
Token	The word-chunks AI actually reads and writes (roughly ¾ of a word each). Mostly matters when a tool talks about limits or pricing.
Machine learning	The broader technique of teaching software from examples instead of writing rules by hand. AI's parent category; fine to use the terms loosely.
Algorithm	Any step-by-step procedure a computer follows. The word sounds precise but is used for everything; on its own it tells you almost nothing.
GPT	"Generative pre-trained transformer" — the architecture behind many models and the reason ChatGPT is named that. You never need the long version.
Multimodal	A model that handles more than text: reads images, hears audio, describes photos. Why students can now snap a picture of a worksheet and ask for answers.

The school-safety words

PII	Personally identifiable information — anything that could identify a specific student: name, ID, photo, or a unique combination of details. The one hard rule: student PII never goes into a public AI tool.
FERPA	The federal law protecting student education records. Typing student information into a consumer chatbot can put you on the wrong side of it — de-identify instead.
COPPA	The federal law behind most "13 and up" age limits on consumer AI tools. Why students under 13 shouldn't have accounts on public chatbots.
De-identification	Rewriting a prompt so no one could tell which child it's about: strip the identity, generalize, describe the need — "a 7th grader reading below grade level," never a name.
Public AI tool	A consumer chatbot with no contract with your district (free ChatGPT, Gemini, etc.). Fine for adult planning with no student data; not a place for anything about a specific child.
District-approved tool	An AI product your district has vetted and signed a data-privacy agreement with. The difference isn't the AI — it's the contract about where data goes.
AI detector	Software claiming to spot AI-written work. Unreliable enough that major providers pulled theirs — false accusations are common. Better evidence: your knowledge of the student's writing, and process work.
Academic integrity policy	Your school's rules on what AI help is allowed on student work. If yours doesn't mention AI yet, clear expectations from you, stated per-assignment, fill the gap.

Buzzwords, decoded

Prompt engineering	A grand name for a simple skill: writing clear, specific requests. If you can write good sub plans, you can do this.
AI literacy	Knowing what AI can and can't do, when to trust it, and how to use it responsibly. What this page is. Increasingly named in state guidance.
AI agent	AI that takes multi-step actions on its own (browsing, booking, filing) instead of just chatting. Coming to school software; worth knowing the word.
Open source model	A model whose underlying weights anyone can download and run. Matters for tech departments; for classrooms it changes little.
Fine-tuning	Extra training that specializes a model for one job — how companies build "AI tutors" from general models. Marketing loves this word.
Wrapper	A product that is mostly a familiar AI model with a new interface on top — many "AI for education" tools. Ask what the tool adds beyond the chatbot you already have.

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